

Productivity Tips

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Introduction

Nearly everyone wants to be more productive. There is a huge amount of advice,¹. Before diving into more practical advice, it is worth considering what makes someone productive or unproductive and the broader goals.

I think it is important why we aim to be productive. After all, with infinite time and no deadlines, productivity stops being important. But in reality, my personal philosophy is to use productivity as a tool to create free time for health, activities, and people you care about while still achieving your goals. To this end, explicitly or implicitly recognizing the things important to you can be productive. Being fast at responding to emails frees up more time for research. Being a productive researcher frees up time for friends and family. When thinking of how to be productive, I try to answer a few different questions, and follow a few principles.

Guiding questions

Consolidate recurring effort into one-time effort

Often, replacing long-term recurring tasks with short-term large tasks helps productivity. Even if replacing a short-term task with a long-term task requires a bit more time, the mental energy and scheduling flexibility created by investing that time can outweigh the lost time (with reasonable limits). Often what makes tasks hard is their recurring nature. It takes consistent energy, and a commitment to complete the task even in weeks where there may be other more important things to manage.

Money can be thought of as a conversion of effort. Spending money on recurring costs is the same as spending the time taken to earn that money. These transactions aren't always lossy, either if the recurring cost is cheap, you earn enough, or you have enough spare time, but generally the act of purchasing recurring items should also be considered part of the time cost. I have also found myself using less disposable items where possible, with the added benefit of eco-friendliness.

Eliminate redundancy

Is this tool redundant? I like to use a mail client, not for any composition feature, but because I can consolidate my email accounts across Gmail and Outlook and view them all in the same feed. Similarly, I would not purchase a dicer if I have a knife. A hybrid wok with a lid is also a great kitchen implement, since it can function as both a pot and pan, and can handle many types of ranges. I personally prefer temperature and scratch-resistant nonstick and silicone, since the time taken to clean stainless steel or maintain and season cast iron (not to mention it isn't easy to handle) makes it not worth it. Redundancy can also create major problems, like inconsistencies between C.V. and Website. In fact, this is why I created my website using Typst - so that I could do both at once (which I learned from brutal experience how badly I could let the two get out of sync when accidentally submitting a version of my C.V. with incorrect dates in my grad school applications²).

Automate or build a quick tool

Can I write a script or build a tool quickly to solve this? With generative AI and some simple scripting, it is becoming easier and easier to write small scripts. Although generative AI can sometimes struggle with larger projects, for these sorts of smaller scripts it can be very convenient.

¹Matt Might wrote an excellent post on his blog on this as well

²Thankfully nearly every school let me submit a new version of my C.V. since I submitted everything several weeks early in case of disaster.

Simple emails can be responded to more quickly with generative AI and automatic responses. It can be unnecessarily floral, but this may not matter much in all settings, especially for short responses.

Google Calendar has an appointments feature through which other people can book your time. This saves the effort of managing your calendar and setting up appointments (which I always found to get confusing and redundant quickly). I also use the tasks feature quite extensively. The integration with Thunderbird isn't the best by default, but Provider for Google Calendar seems to fill in the gaps.

Favor simple, existing solutions

Try to keep solutions simple. Although it can be better to manage your own tools, also check for simple, readily available solutions.

Weigh maintenance cost against benefits

Does owning a possession save me more time/energy/effort than the effort required to maintain the possessions? I find a good rule of thumb is if there is another tool that does the same task with similar effort. In the kitchen, a good example is a knife. Most people only need one or two knives in their kitchen. As long as it is maintained, one well-kept chef's knife can handle nearly everything a paring knife, bread knife, or cleaver would, so the time spent cleaning, storing, sharpening, and honing several specialized knives vastly outweighs the time saved by using each one for its "ideal" task. Watches have become useless in an era where everyone has a phone. There is an apocryphal story told among Quakers about William Penn's sword³. Every item has some burden on the mind, time, energy, etc. There is nothing wrong with any item inherently, but for each item, "hold it as long as thou canst".

Reduce recurring energy costs

How much energy does keeping up with this task take? Is there a way to get out of it or consolidate it? One major drain of energy for me is notifications and emails. A few years ago, my phone broke due to a manufacturing issue. The phone manufacturer was willing to replace it for free, but submitting the claim took 2 weeks and I didn't have another phone I could use as a backup. In that time, I felt incredibly focused and present, since I was forced to let people wait for a response. In real life this is impractical, so I ultimately went back to using email more regularly, but this showed up in other ways. I ditched smartwatches (phone fitness tracking has gotten good enough that it doesn't seem to offer much advantage anyways beyond sleep tracking).

I tend to interact through the internet most through RSS feeds and newsletters, but I was running into a few problems. Most functionally, my inbox was getting cluttered, and it took sustained energy to keep a clean inbox. I also was getting enough notifications in one day that I felt constantly attached to my phone to respond and deal with the email. Most of these were not important and did not need me to respond, but making that decision still took consistent effort, especially for newsletters which had different schedules. I found that using an aggregation tool like Mailbrew was really helpful to curb my usage. My biggest complaint was that the number of sources was limited and I was not able to set an email for days of week, but it serves the purpose well.⁴

Control accessibility to shape behavior

How does the accessibility of this thing change how I use it? If your phone is always nearby and fun to use, it's easy to reach out and engage. To some extent, this is why social media is so addictive. Social media is easy to engage with endlessly without cost. Thus, block Instagram, Youtube, etc on the phone. Unsubscribe and unfollow. XKCD had another idea to increase the barrier to start, but I haven't found a good extension implementing this (the one in the description does not work). It can be helpful that every youtube channel automatically

³Story

⁴Eliminate Temptation to Waste Time

generates an RSS feed which you can subscribe to⁵. I personally found using a slow/cheap phone with a small screen and Gcam to be good at making phone activities less fun while still being functional enough to check email and respond to messages (plus its cheap to replace!). You can always unblock these websites, but having to unblock it every time you want to access creates sufficient barrier to avoid compulsive checking.

In the other direction, make it easier to access productive behaviors. I find this most obvious with food. If I keep healthy food around and prepared, I almost always find myself eating healthy without thinking about it. When I wanted to practice piano more during COVID, doing my work near the piano made me naturally play more since I interacted with it so much.

⁵XKCD